

The big name who could be leaving Brussels

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Presented by Amazon By NICHOLAS VINOCUR with GERARDO FORTUNA GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. Let's go. In today's Playbook: — Spain's election means hop

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GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. Let's go.

In today's Playbook:

- Spain's election means hopes of a quick deal on the MFF are fading, officials tell Playbook.
- Inside the EU's latest exam fiasco.

— Faces in the crowd: António Costa, Ditte Juul Jørgensen, Pedro Lourtie, Bjoern Seibert, David Oppenheimer, Thérèse Blanchet, Marta Kos, Luca Niculescu, Herman Van Rompuy and more ...

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Ian unpack the Brussels fallout from Pedro Sánchez's election gamble — and why Ursula von der Leyen will likely ride it out.

**A message from Amazon: Businesses across Europe are using the AWS Cloud to modernise essential industries. In Valmacca, Italy, xFarm uses cloud technology to help farmers make data-driven decisions, improve productivity, and support more sustainable agricultural practices—connecting farms across Europe and beyond. Hear from more AWS customers across Europe. **

DRIVING THE DAY

EXCLUSIVE — COSTA'S DEALMAKER SETS HIS SIGHTS ON NEW YORK: The chief of staff to European Council President António Costa is eyeing a move to head the EU's delegation at the United Nations next year, four EU officials and diplomats told Playbook and Jacopo Barigazzi.

Pedro Lourtie, a Portuguese diplomat who's been at Costa's side since 2024, has applied for the prestigious role, which will become vacant next year, the officials said. It's one of a slew of high-profile jobs up for grabs in the EU's diplomatic network, including head of delegation in Saudi Arabia and deputy head of the bloc's office in China.

On the record: Lourtie himself and a spokesperson for Costa declined to comment.

Central figure: As chief of staff to the European Council president, Lourtie forms a duo with European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen's chief of staff, Bjoern Seibert, and is in charge of delicate preparatory talks with national capitals ahead of gatherings of EU leaders. He also carries out sensitive missions for his boss — such as when he opened a communication channel with counterparts in Moscow with an eye to ending the war in Ukraine, only to have EU leaders object to the idea.

Exit stage left? Lourtie's potential departure isn't linked to that controversial Russia outreach, two of the officials said. If awarded the U.N. job, Lourtie would be leaving before the end of Costa's two-and-a-half-year term in office, which expires in May next year.

It could work out perfectly, because that coincides with Portugal becoming a non-permanent member of the U.N. Security Council for 2027-2028. Having a Portuguese diplomat representing the EU at the U.N. could help to advance the bloc's interests.

Next cab off the rank: Lourtie's deputy, David Oppenheimer, is well placed to succeed him, officials said.

Another important change is expected at the Council of the EU, the legislative body that represents member states: France's Thérèse Blanchet, its secretary-general, is expected to retire. A decision on her replacement is also expected early next year.

Normal: Council presidents switching their chiefs of staff during their term isn't unheard of, one diplomat said, pointing to the example of former Council President Herman Van Rompuy, who appointed Didier Seeuws for the final two years of his five years in office.

Smooth sailing: EU leaders must vote on the renewal of Council presidents, though traditionally they have decided to continue with the person already in place.

BIG AND BREAKING

SPANISH AFTERSHOCKS: Defeat for Pedro Sánchez in Spain's snap election could destabilize the EU by putting the Socialists and Democrats on the back foot in Brussels and pushing them into a more confrontational stance, Max Grier reports. (More on the fallout from Spain's snap election lower down.)

STRINGS ATTACHED: The Commission is expected to propose sector-specific "safeguard clauses" in future accession treaties — an addition pushed by cabinets earlier this week to the pre-enlargement review prepared by enlargement service DG ENEST and Commissioner Marta Kos, which is due for approval by the College of Commissioners today.

Translation: Joining the club could come with more strings attached, including trade restrictions more commonly associated with countries outside it, according to a draft seen by Playbook's Gerardo Fortuna. The approach would be applied "as appropriate" first to Montenegro's accession arrangements, but is mostly aimed at addressing Kyiv's huge agricultural sector.

ALL EYES ON CHINA: Ditte Juul Jørgensen, director-general of the Commission's trade department, will update EU ambassadors this morning on the state of EU-China talks following trips to Beijing and Washington. Her boss, Maroš Šefčovič, will debrief envoys on Sunday after his own two-day visit to China. Camille Gijs and Carlo Martuscelli report in Morning Trade (for subscribers).

That's after France and Berlin jointly argued in a letter and position paper that the European Commission needs tools to be able to hit back harder and faster against Beijing in a trade dispute, Hans von der Burchard and Carlo report .

TRY AGAIN: Romania's President Nicușor Dan has asked senior diplomat Luca Niculescu to form a government in Bucharest — after his three previous nominees for PM failed to break the deadlock.

SPAIN DENTS HOPES FOR A QUICK BUDGET DEAL

A NEW WRENCH IN THE BUDGET WORKS: Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez's decision to call a snap election makes it less likely that the EU will strike a deal on its long-term budget by the end of the year, two EU diplomats and an EU official told Playbook.

Bad timing: Madrid is among the most prominent voices in the "friends of cohesion," a group of 17 countries that wants to expand the bloc's long-term budget, the Multiannual Financial Framework. That's unlikely to change regardless of who wins, but the horse-trading required to form a government could make it harder for the winner to sign off on a tricky EU budget compromise, the officials said.

"It's not going to do any good for the MFF," said an official from the European Commission granted anonymity to speak frankly on a sensitive topic.

The Nov. 29 election will be "distracting" and won't "incentivize finding compromise," an EU diplomat said. Spain could still be trying to form a government when EU leaders are due to hold crunch talks on a final deal in December, making a big breakthrough even less likely than it already was, said a second diplomat.

António Costa had hoped to have an MFF deal in writing before a succession of major elections next year. France holds the first round of its presidential contest in April, followed by parliamentary elections in Greece and Poland. Spain's vote brings forward that timeline of potential disruption, at a moment when leaders seem as far apart as ever.

Glass half full: That said, a victorious Spanish leader — if they're able to form a government — could actually have a positive influence on MFF talks, the second diplomat said. They could have a "new and positive influence on the European stage. And sometimes it's easier to play that role after an election."

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

EU lawmakers have called for a €2 billion investment fund for the European Critical Raw Materials Centre, but what is that? The European Commission announced plans last year to open the center to help ensure the EU has reliable access to supplies of critical raw materials such as lithium and cobalt. It would be asked to monitor and assess the need for those materials, as well as to coordinate joint purchasing and stockpiling. The Commission has yet to publish a formal proposal setting out how that would work.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Ian asked listeners to write in with their experiences trying to get a job at an EU institution. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

TESTING TIMES

PANIC AT THE BERLAYMONT: Spare a thought for the Commission's temporary and contract agents. More than 3,000 of them sat an internal test to secure the ultimate Eurocrat prize: to become fully fledged EU officials. A whopping 46% failed, Gerardo Fortuna reports.

But the candidates don't yet know if they're among that group. They were told the overall failure rate but not whether they had passed or flunked the exam, three EU officials told Playbook. The result: what one official described as "pure anxiety."

Canteen confidential: If you happened to eavesdrop over lunch in the Berlaymont last week (like we did), chances are you heard about little else. Confidence wasn't exactly overflowing. "I flunked for sure," one official told Playbook when asked about the test.

Blame the brain test: Making things particularly nerve-wracking was the first appearance in this test of the infamous cognitive assessment, which has been criticized by non-native English speakers for not being properly translated into French and German.

Last Chance Saloon: For those whose contracts are about to expire, this could have been their final shot at getting a full-time job. If their contract runs out before the next internal competition — and there's no date for one yet — they're back on the outside.

DASHBOARD

Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sánchez, under pressure over corruption cases involving members of his family and the migrant crisis in the Spanish enclave of Ceuta, on Monday appeared to pin his campaign for reelection on the country's housing crisis , which has led to nationwide protests in recent weeks.

5 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

ECHOES OF EUROPE'S DEBT CRISIS: France's deteriorating fiscal situation is bringing back memories of the EU's sovereign debt crisis — and raising fears that it could cause a broader, regional problem.

And it's not just France: The EU risks descending into crisis if the bloc fails to revive its flatlining economy , Brussels' top financial official warned after retiring from a four-decade career at the European Commission .

LANDING IN GREECE: U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio is visiting Athens for high-level meetings focusing on the transfer of liquefied natural gas through Greece, regional security and U.S. arms sales, Nektaria Stamouli reports.

NOT BACKING DOWN: French far-left presidential candidate Jean-Luc Mélenchon has urged his supporters to join nationwide protests today in support of students, despite being accused of instigating violence.

AI THREAT: Senior EU officials are warning that a sweeping new plan to arm the bloc's police agency, Europol, for the AI era could threaten Europeans' privacy.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Partly sunny with a gentle breeze. High of 21C.

MANNEKEN PIS GRADUATES: You may notice Brussels' most famous statue sporting an academic look: Manneken Pis is spending the week in a university gown to mark graduation season.

Equal-opportunity dressing: He starts by celebrating the Dutch-language VUB, while keeping the gown on for graduates from ULB, Haute École Francisco Ferrer and the Académie royale des Beaux-Arts (even Manneken Pis knows not to pick a linguistic side).

Watch it happen: VUB graduates take to the Brussels Town Hall balcony today, to the applause of those assembled in the Grand-Place. Don't expect American-style flying mortarboards: It's more civic ceremony than academic mayhem.

HOUSE HUNTING, ANYONE? The Brussels regional government plans to sell the minister-president's official residence, Bruzz reports . It's part of a wider effort to slim down the administration, as the government tries to get its finances under control.

CLAY FACE: For something considerably more avant-garde, Artonov's "Hybridation" lands at the Centre culturel d'Uccle at 7:30 p.m. Artists Olivier de Sagazan and Alyzée Soudet Polaris will cover and sculpt their faces with clay until they become almost unrecognizable "living sculptures."

STARTING TODAY: Brussels' "Semaine Numérique," with free events through Oct. 16 on AI, cybersecurity, digital inclusion, 3D printing and digital twins. It's free but registration is required.

MEANWHILE, IN STRASBOURG: Plenary week doesn't have to mean evenings filing parliamentary amendments. Here are some suggestions for readers stuck in the beautiful French city tonight ...

Basket case: SIG Strasbourg kicks off its Basketball Champions League campaign against Legia Warsaw tonight — conveniently just a few meters from Parliament. Tickets start at €20. How often does European sport arrange its calendar around plenary week?

Reader's choice: Novelist Lilia Hassaine is at Librairie Kléber at 6 p.m. to discuss "JE," her new take on the mysterious woman in the attic from Jane Eyre. Entry is free.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Germany's firewall against the far right faces another test as the AfD prepares to take a state parliamentary presidency for the first time, in Saxony-Anhalt.

Paris: Sébastien Lecornu's government faces another day of mass demonstrations and a parliamentary grilling as it struggles to contain the unrest that has disrupted schools and left hundreds injured.

London: Conservative Leader Kemi Badenoch will spend the day before her big conference speech doing wall-to-wall interviews .

Washington: The Supreme Court seems to be torn over a major case that could determine whether municipalities can hold fossil fuel companies liable for climate change.

Ottawa: Conservative Leader Pierre Poilievre is setting the House agenda with a motion aimed at lowering diesel prices.

Canberra: The opposition Coalition is set to unveil plans to sharply cut migrant numbers to draw conservative voters from One Nation.

** Start the day with Spanish politics. Madrid Playbook, launching on October 13, delivers sharp reporting, context and political intelligence you need to understand Spain's day ahead, in Spanish. Sign up for Madrid Playbook .**

AGENDA

- The College of Commissioners meets in Strasbourg.
- Coreper II meets at 9 a.m.
- The Political and Security Committee meets at 9:30 a.m.
- The European Parliament plenary session continues in Strasbourg. European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen participates in the debate in preparation for the European Council meeting of Oct. 15-16. Watch live .
- European Parliament President Roberta Metsola meets Portuguese Prime Minister Luís Montenegro at 10:05 a.m. and does a joint press point at 10:15 a.m. (watch live), before the “This is Europe” debate in Parliament at 10:30 a.m.
- Metsola receives Apple Executive Chair Tim Cook at 2:15 p.m. and Bill Browder of the Global Magnitsky Justice Campaign at 4:30 p.m.
- Commission Executive Vice President Teresa Ribera meets the Eurocities Shadow Commission.
- Mediterranean Commissioner Dubravka Šuica addresses the CDayz 2026 international conference on AI and emerging digital technologies at the University of Zadar via video message.
- Sustainable Transport Commissioner Apostolos Tzitzikostas participates in the EU-India Aviation Dialogue with Indian Civil Aviation Minister Kinjarapu Rammohan Naidu in Delhi.
- Intergenerational Fairness Commissioner Glenn Micallef meets representatives of the Eurocities network.
- Fisheries and Oceans Commissioner Costas Kadis participates in the awards ceremony and opening reception of the Malta Maritime Summit 2026 in Valletta.
- Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni meets Lithuanian President Gitanas Nausėda at Palazzo Chigi at 4:30 p.m.

BIRTHDAYS

MEP Pierre Jouvét; former MEPs Livia Járóka, Alexis Georgoulis, Monika Smolková and Steven Woolfe; EuroHPC JU's Josephine Wood; former Belgian PM Yves Leterme; Slovak President Peter Pellegrini; Guillaume Mitterrand, from the Dutch Defense Ministry; Artur Orkisz, of the Norwegian embassy in

Washington; the BBC's Rowan Bridge; Belgian politician Pierre-Yves Jeholet; Friends of Europe's Dharmendra Kanani.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

****A message from Amazon:** Founded to support the digital evolution of farming, xFarm uses the AWS Cloud to power a platform that helps farmers improve productivity while keeping sustainability at the core of their operations. By turning agricultural data into actionable insights, xFarm enables farmers to make smarter decisions in an increasingly complex environmental and economic landscape. "With the AWS Cloud, we can connect farms around the world, transforming agriculture through innovation while keeping sustainability at the heart of everything we do," says Giovanni Causapruno of xFarm. xFarm is one of many European businesses building on the AWS Cloud to operate at scale, strengthen resilience, and support more sustainable food systems. The AWS Cloud helps xFarm extend its impact across borders—supporting farmers as they adapt to today's environmental and operational challenges. Learn more about how businesses across Europe are growing with the AWS Cloud at [AWS.eu](https://aws.eu). ******

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